



Prof. S. Sadagopan at the India Software Product Management Summit 2020 (ISPMS 2020)

the free medical centre cum dispensary run by the Ramakrishna Mission. I used to distribute medicines as per the prescriptions.”

Prof. Sadagopan is to date quite fascinated by the libraries at his school and Ramakrishna Mission. He still remembers the amazing teachers that mentored him and encouraged him on a lifelong spiritual journey. Prof. Sadagopan opines, “My experiences at school and Ramakrishna Mission shaped my personality.”

“I have learned a lot while volunteering with Ramakrishna Mission for a charitable dispensary project. The patients had to pay five paise for availing of the consultation. Even in those days, five paise was a nominal amount, but collecting the same involved lots of work. So, I asked Swamiji the reason behind making the service chargeable with a nominal amount. He explained that those ‘5 paise’ contributions from each patient were hardly making any difference in our overall cost. However, that contribution would ensure the sincerity and regularity of the patients for that service. Actually, after paying that nominal fee they valued the service more and stopped wasting medicines. It was a touching lesson for me.”

Pursuing the engineering dream

Prof. Sadagopan completed his schooling in 1967 and joined the College of Engineering, Guindy, University of Madras, India, to pursue BE (Hons) (1973). He narrates “It is one of the oldest engineering colleges in the country. I was a day scholar there. My house was about five kilometres away and I used to commute by bicycle.”

The college gave him a much wider canvas to paint. While remembering his learning days, Prof. Sadagopan says, “In those days, there was no separate computer science department. However, we started with analogue computers, and later, a very modest IBM 1620 computer in a government department. There was a professor in charge who used to allow us extra practice time, after office hours. However, there was not enough money to pay for IBM training; so we all used to dig up the manuals and learn to program by doing it ourselves.”

During his engineering days, Prof. Sadagopan got opportunities to participate in various interesting projects and to do an internship at a reputed company. However, the huge library at Guindy was the most important attraction. “I still remember there was a famous textbook called ‘The Dynamics and Thermodynamics of Compressible

Fluid Flow’ by Professor AH Shapiro of MIT.” The librarian was struggling to find the right place—was she to put it under dynamics, thermodynamics, or fluids? I guided her to resolve this matter and we became good friends. As a result, I was allowed to borrow more books. I think books have been an integral part of my life.”

Then, the Indian higher education system was in an experimental phase concerning the engineering syllabus. It allowed Prof. Sadagopan to study more elective courses and interesting projects even outside the department. He focused more on mathematics and electronics and also did some unusual experiments.

Sadagopan defines himself as a ‘365 day holiday’ person as he has been enjoying his study and work just like his leisure. “When people talk about work-life balance, I get amused, because I think that it seamlessly flows into each other,” he explains. His zeal for learning manifested even in leisure pursuits, exemplified by his grasp of Hindi and translation of Prabhudutt Brahmachari’s lectures during his college days.

Shaping up the professional life

“I wanted to go for academics and higher studies after completing my engineering degree,” Prof. Sadagopan informs. However, destiny led him to Engineers India, a Delhi-based consulting firm. A talent search culminated in his recruitment, offering a novel perspective on his potential. He remembers, “They had a very unusual policy as they invited only the top two rank holders of twenty premiere Universities for an interview. So as a young person of about 20 years, I found that suddenly a company took the trouble of discovering me, even giving me a first-class train ticket to go to Delhi, and finally appointed me in a job for which I never applied. And of course, the job was also paying well, a four-figure salary of 1,040 rupees. It